Start Here

Eleven texts, in the order they are best read

A reading order for the PDFs in this folder, with one line on why each text sits where it does.

HOW TO USE THESE FILES

These are single-text reading editions, set in a narrow page so they can be read on a phone at fit-width without zooming. Each one opens with a title page, then a short factual introduction, then the text with its own numbering kept in the margin, then a colophon naming the translator and the source page.

Read the introduction in each PDF before the text. It says what survives, in what language, how much is missing, and which recension or translation you are holding. Two of these texts are incomplete by nature: the Gospel of Mary is missing its first six pages and pages 11-14, and the Gospel of Judas has holes throughout. The introductions mark exactly where.

The order below is a reading order, not a ranking. Six texts carry the main line; four shorter works support them; the last is an appendix.

THE READING ORDER

1 **The Gospel of Thomas**

114 sayings and no story. Start here: short units, no cosmology to learn first, and the only text in this set that stands completely on its own.

2 **The Gospel of Mary**

Short, narrative, and it takes up what Thomas leaves open - who is allowed to teach. Read directly after Thomas.

3 **The Gospel of Truth**

A homily, not a gospel, with no divisions to hold on to; it reads well once the sayings form is familiar.

4 **The Apocryphon of John**

The long recension: the fullest map of the myth the first three assume. The longest of the six.

5 **The Gospel of Philip**

Sayings and sacramental teaching. It makes more sense once the myth from Apocryphon of John is in place.

6 **The Gospel of Judas**

A dialogue using the same mythic furniture, and the most contested text here. Last of the main six.

7 The Hypostasis of the Archons

Supporting text. A short retelling of Genesis 1-6 from the rulers' side - the clearest single account of the demiurge story.

8 On the Origin of the World

Supporting text. The long version of that same story; read it after Hypostasis, which it expands.

9 The Thunder, Perfect Mind

Supporting text. No narrative and no myth: a voice speaking in paradoxes. It can be read at any point.

10 The Dialogue of the Savior

Supporting text. A dialogue with the disciples, useful for comparing how these texts stage the same teaching scenes as Mary and Judas.

11 The Gospel of the Egyptians

Appendix. The most technical text in the set - a Sethian liturgy with vowel strings and doxologies. Read it last, if at all.

ONE THING TO KEEP IN MIND

These texts are not a canon. They are not one movement, one school, or one doctrine, and they do not agree with each other. They were written and copied across roughly the second to fourth centuries by competing groups - Sethian, Valentinian, and others whose names we no longer know - who argued with each other as much as with the churches that later defined orthodoxy. Some were composed in Greek and survive only in Coptic translation; some are complete, some are fragments of a single damaged book.

So read them as arguments rather than as a single teaching, and expect the same characters and the same myths to be put to different uses from one text to the next. That disagreement is the subject, not an obstacle to it.

If you read only one, read Thomas. It is the only text here that stands alone, without the myth or the liturgy that the others assume.